

CS 141 Fall 2025

Professors:

Prof. Jaime Spacco, SMC E-210, 309-341-7956, [Jaime Spacco](#)

Office hours: MW 5th, W 6th.

Prof. Jurdana Iqrah, SMC E-205, 309-341-7167, [Jurdana Masuma Iqrah](#)

Office hours: I teach 3rd and 6th hour most days, but I'm usually able to talk whenever my office door is open, or email for an appointment.

Teaching Assistants:

Name	Lab	Office Hours	Location
Juan Pablo Perez Mejia			
Khanh Le Gia	2	4-5pm	Under the whale
Ahmad Al-Sou'd			
Ronak Jha			
TBA			

Course Overview

This course teaches problem-solving on a computer. We will be using the Java programming language, but the point of the class is *not* just to learn Java. Instead, you are learning how to express what you want the computer to do, with Java being the specific language you are using. We aim to teach programming as a tool for use in Computer Science or your own field.

Meetings

There are three lecture sections for this course and three sections for the lab. You can match up any lab with any lecture. The content is the same across course sections and labs.

Exams

There are 2 midterms and a final exam. All exams are written exams in class.

Midterms are Week 4 (**Friday October 10**) and Week 8 (**Friday November 7**). Plus a final exam during finals period.

We provide “practica exams” (which is just the exams from the previous term) about a week before the exam to help you study.

Resources

This class does not have a traditional textbook. We are experimenting with using an online textbook from Runestone. As you read, you'll complete exercises to illustrate the material and get your first practice with it. The online book is free. You must attempt each exercise to receive credit; you don't need to get everything correct.

We are trying out a free "Classroom Response System" called PollEverywhere this term.

We will be using [Google Classroom](#). We will post copies of the slides, assignments, and announcements there. Everyone should have been invited to the class; if we missed you, please email us.

Peer Instruction

This class will be taught using Peer Instruction, in which the lecture is periodically interrupted with multiple-choice questions that you answer and then discuss with your peers. (These questions are graded for *participation*, so don't worry if you can't answer them all.) Peer Instruction has been shown to improve your learning; you learn more by explaining your ideas to others and hearing their explanations than by just listening to me.

To get the benefits of Peer Instruction, you need to participate actively. Attempt to answer the questions correctly. Be sure to explain your reasoning and listen to the reasoning of other students when you're in your group. This can be uncomfortable since you'll have to admit when you don't understand something, but this is an opportunity to get clarification from your peers.

Don't use AI in this class

Don't use AI in this class because you have to learn at least the basics of programming, and you aren't going to do that if you use AI. That's like going to the gym and having someone else lift the weights! Programming assignments in CS-141 have to be tightly specified, which means AI can do a lot of them. Nobody is going to hire you to feed clear specifications to an AI.

There are productive ways to use AI, but you need to wait until later in the major to be able to take advantage of them.

We can usually figure out if you're using AI, and we will refer you to the Honor Board. It's a very unpleasant process. Please don't do it. Do your own work.

Succeeding in this class

Expect to work for this class. This is one of three classes that make up a full-time schedule so you should spend about 13 1/3 hours/week on it.

Be sure to keep up with the reading and assignments. Come to class and participate fully in the activities. Ask questions when there is something that you don't understand. After that, the best way to spend your time on the course is to practice. Write little programs that use the concepts we've learned in class. This includes redoing problems we do in class or you do for homework; just erase your solution and see if you can recreate it. You don't truly understand what we're doing in class unless you can apply it yourself. The critical thing is that you spend time thinking about and writing code. (Remember how long it took you to become a proficient writer. Learning to program is every bit as much a process and requires every bit as much practice.)

Rough schedule

The following is a rough schedule of what we'll cover each week. It will likely be tweaked during the term, so don't expect this to be our exact schedule.

Week 1: Introduction to code. Conditionals and booleans. While loops.

Week 2: For loops. Reference types. Strings.

Week 3: Input and output. Static methods.

Week 4: Functions. **Exam 1.**

Week 5: Arrays.

Week 6: 2D arrays.

Week 7: Classes.

Week 8: Greenfoot. **Exam 2.**

Week 9: Recursion.

Week 10: Recursion.

Assignments

- **Reading and Runestone Academy problems.** As preparation for class, you'll be expected to read the interactive textbook before most class periods. This is your first introduction to the material. There will be two kinds of problems to complete in the book: participation activities, which just require you to do them (watch an animation, etc), and challenge activities, which require you to answer short questions successfully. These may be assigned at different times for the same textbook section; we're still figuring out how to use the interactive textbook format.

- **Clicker questions.** The in-class questions will be graded for participation only. You should attend and answer questions during all but three of the lectures for full credit.
- **Lab assignments.** These are your primary homework assignments. (There may be small other assignments as well.) They will give you hands-on practice with the course material. The idea is that you begin them during our lab period when it's easy to get questions answered. Then whatever you don't finish during the lab period becomes your homework for the week, due before the beginning of the next lab.
- **Exams.** This class will have two exams plus a final exam. Each exam will be cumulative, emphasizing material covered since the last exam. These exams will be in-class but open notes.

Late work

Runestone (5%): Get these done before class, as the class period will focus on the readings. *At best you get half credit for anything that is late.* You don't need to get all of the right answers; just answer all of the questions.

Attendance and Clicker Questions (5%): You get credit for attending class and participating in "clicker questions". You do not need to get them correct. You can miss three classes with no penalty; after that you begin losing points to your attendance score. If you use your three missed classes to sleep in, and then you get sick and have to miss 3 classes, that's on you. On the other hand, if you get really sick, like you get mononucleosis and have to miss 2 weeks of class, or if you have a personal emergency, let us know. That's a different situation.

Labs: Lab assignments are officially due Tuesday before your lab period. Everyone has an automatic extension for the rest of that day (until Tuesday at midnight). We may release solutions or discuss them in class at any time after the automatic extension, after which those problems **cannot** be submitted. We try to keep the late penalties to 10% after 24 hours but before 1 week, and 20% after a week.

Exams: You should not miss an exam. If you have to miss an exam, let us know as soon as possible in advance.

Absences

Regular attendance is expected and attendance will be taken most days. If you miss class for any reason, you are still responsible for that day's material so you need to get notes from someone. It is possible to make up exams and get excused from the day's clicker questions if you notify the professor of your section **ahead of time** and have a valid reason, such as significant illness (doctor's verification may be required) or are on college business (athletic competition or class field trip).

Policy on Collaboration

Reading assignments and exams in this class must be completed individually. You are allowed to talk with others about the homework and are encouraged to work together in small groups (2-3 students). **Even when working together, you must write your submission yourself and understand it completely.** In addition, you must do two things:

1. First, you must acknowledge all collaborators by adding a note to your solution describing who helped you and how. Get in the habit of doing this as soon as you talk.
2. Secondly, you must avoid "collaborations" where one person gives the solution to another. When working together, each person should contribute ideas. If one person is helping another, the helper can explain concepts and guide the "helpee" toward a solution but cannot tell them how to solve the problem. In all collaborations, everyone is expected to understand the entire solution, and each individual must write up their solution separately.
3. Your professors are aware that the AI tools can be used to solve coding problems. As with the previous point, you should also avoid 'AI collaborations' where the AI provides solutions. In

summary, for this course use of AI is not allowed. Remember that most of your points will be awarded for work done during class times. Testing your understanding with homework is a crucial part of learning the material so that you can succeed on these in-class assessments.

4. The same ideas apply to getting help from other 'inanimate' sources. You may look at other sources for examples or conceptual help but not for actual solutions. If you use the web or a book, you must cite this source, and you are expected to write your own solution, so do not copy text or code from another source. Some problems assigned for this class may have been used previously, but you are expected not to seek solutions deliberately. (If you come across one accidentally, let us know and we will give you a modified assignment.)

Please feel free to contact us if you have any questions about this policy.

Academic accommodations

Students who qualify for accommodations in this class are encouraged to contact Stephanie Grimes (sgrimes@knox.edu) in the Office of Disability Support Services as soon as possible to ensure that such accommodations are implemented in a timely fashion.

Extra credit

We will give extra credit several times this term for attending colloquium talks sponsored by the CS department (possibly other departments, depending on the talk) and submitting a short write-up about the talk. This offer applies to any qualifying talk for which you are not otherwise getting credit; you should not submit a write-up for this class and also for another class.

In order to get credit for a talk, submit a quick writeup (~1 page) to Prof. Spacco (jspacco@knox.edu) within a week of the talk. DO NOT just summarize the talk; we want to hear what you thought about it or how it relates to other things you've seen/heard. While your write-up doesn't have to be brilliant prose, we do expect you to write thoughtfully and correctly and may return your writeup for revisions before giving you credit.

Grading

At the end of the term, all of your work will combined into an overall course percentage based on the following weights:

Runestone Questions (in the reading)	5%
Clicker Questions	5%
Labs	30%
Exam #1	20%
Exam #2	20%

Final	20%
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The range of scores mapping to each grade will be determined at the end of the term. The mapping will not be stricter than the "standard" 90/80/70/60 and may be more generous. In general, spend your time learning the material rather than worrying about your grade, but feel free to talk with us if you are concerned about it.